non-conformists. He believes in the straight and narrow path of true orthodoxy and those who stray from this must forthwith remove themselves from his ken. How then am I to remove this doubt and difficulty? Will Sir Mohamad help in solving the riddle?

Almora District Jail

21 August 1935

4. Jawaharlal Nehru, ‘Orthodox of All Religions, Unite!’

(*The Modern Review* [1935], Vol. 58, No. 5, pp. 625–31)

SOME YEARS AGO I happened to be in Benares and as I was driving through the narrow city streets, my car was held up by a crowd. A procession was passing through and, apart from the processionists, there were many sightseers and little boys intent on sharing in the fun. Crowds interest me and I got down from the car to find out what was afoot. The procession was certainly an interesting one and it had certain unique features. We saw Brahmans, the most orthodox of their kind, with all manner of caste-marks proudly displayed on their foreheads marching shoulder to shoulder with bearded moulvis, the priests from the ghats fraternized with the mullahs from the mosques, and one of the standards they carried in triumph bore the flaming devise: *Hindu Musalman ekta ki jai* – Victory to Hindu-Muslim Unity! Very gratifying, we thought. But still what was all this about?

We soon found out from the cries and the many other standards they carried. This was a joint protest by the orthodox of both religions against the Sarda Act (or perhaps it was a Bill at the time) which prohibited marriages of girls under fourteen. The pious and the holy of both faiths had joined ranks and bands to declare that they would not submit to this outrage on their deepest convictions and most cherished rights. Were they going to be bullied by the threats of so-called reformers into giving up their right to marry child-wives? Never! Law or no law, they would continue to marry little immature girls – for was not post-puberty marriage a sin? – and thus